

Peruvian Women Heal Themselves with Song, Art

The 36-year-old Peruvian artist Sadith Silvano makes creations born of ancient songs.

Brush in hand, eyes on the cloth, the Peruvian woman paints as she sings. And through her voice, her ancestors speak.

“When we paint, we listen to the inspiration that comes from the music and connect to nature, to our elders,” said Silvano.

The artist now lives and works in Lima, Peru, where she moved 20 years ago from Paoyhan. It is a Shipibo-Konibo Indigenous community located in the Amazon.

Crafts made by Sadith Silvano sit at her home and workshop in Lima, Peru, Saturday, Oct. 19, 2024. “Every design tells a story,” said Silvano, from Paoyhan, a Shipibo-Konibo Indigenous community in the Amazon. (AP Photo/Guadalupe Pardo)

“These pieces are sacred,” she added. “We bless our work with the energy of our songs.”

Official data says close to 33,000 Shipibo-Konibo people live in Peru. They are believed to come from the surroundings of the Uyakali river. Many moved to urban areas like Cantagallo, the Lima neighborhood where Silvano lives.

Hand-painted textiles like the ones she makes have slowly gained recognition. Known as “kené,” these works were declared part of the “Cultural Heritage of the Nation” by the Peruvian government in 2008.

Each kené is special, Shipibo craftswomen say. Every design speaks of a woman’s community, her worldview and beliefs.

“Every design tells a story,” Silvano said while dressed in traditional clothing. “It is a way in which a Shipibo woman distinguishes herself.”

Paoyhan, where Silvano was born, is far from Lima. To get there requires an airplane flight and a 12-hour boat trip.

In her hometown, locals rarely speak languages other than Shipibo. Doors and windows there have no locks.

Adela Sampayo, a 48-year-old healer who was born not too far from Paoyhan, moved to Cantagallo in 2000.

But she says that all her skills come from the Amazon River area.

“Since I was a little girl, my mom treated me with traditional medicine,” said Sampayo. “She gave me plants to become stronger, to avoid getting sick, to be courageous,” she added. “That’s how the energy of the plants started growing inside me.”

Sampayo, too, communicates her worldview through her textiles. Though she does not paint, she embroiders, and each thread tells a tale from home.

“Each plant has a spirit,” said the healer, pointing to the leaves embroidered in the cloth. “And medicinal plants come from God.”

The plants painted by Silvano also bear meaning. One of them represents pure love. Another represents a wise man. And another, a serpent.

“The anaconda is special for us,” Silvano said. “It’s our protector, like a god that cares for us and provides food and water.”

In ancient times, she said, her people believed that the sun was their father, and the anacondas were their guardians. Colonization brought Catholicism and their worldview changed.

“Nowadays we have different religions...but we respect our other beliefs too,” Silvano said.

Sadith Silvano, from Paoyhan, a Shipibo-Konibo Indigenous community in the Amazon, paints a tablecloth at her home and workshop in Lima, Peru, Saturday, Oct. 19, 2024. (AP Photo/Guadalupe Pardo)

For many years, after her father took her to Lima hoping for a better future, she thought of her time in the jungle. Life in Paoyhan was not easy, but she learned to be strong at a young age.

“When we encounter difficult times, we overcome them with our therapy: designing, painting, singing,” Silvano said. “We have a song that is melodic and heals our soul, and another one that is inspiring and brings us joy.”

Few Shipibo girls are told to study or make a living of their own, Silvano said. Instead, they are taught to wait for a husband. And once married, they are taught to deal with problems, difficulties, or bad treatment.

“Even though we suffer, people tell us: Take it, he’s the father of your children. Take it, he is your husband,” Silvano said. “But deep inside, we are wounded. So what do we do? We sing.”

The lesson is taught by mothers to daughters: If you are hurt at home, grab your cloth, your brush and leave. Go far away, alone, and sit. Connect with your kené and paint. And while you paint, sing.

“That’s our healing,” Silvano said. “Through our songs, our kenés, we are free.”

I’m John Russell.

Maria Teresa Hernandez reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

brush - n. แปรง (อุปกรณ์ที่มีขนแปรงติดอยู่กับด้ามจับ ใช้สำหรับทาสีโดยเฉพาะ)

inspiration - n. แรงบันดาลใจ (อิทธิพลหรือการกระทำจากสิ่งศักดิ์สิทธิ์ที่เชื่อว่าทำให้บุคคลมีคุณสมบัติที่จะรับและสื่อสารการเปิดเผยอันศักดิ์สิทธิ์)

sacred - adj. ศักดิ์สิทธิ์ (เกี่ยวกับศาสนา, ควรแก่การเคารพ)

courageous - adj. กล้าหาญ (แสดงความสามารถในการทำสิ่งที่ยาก)

textile - n. สิ่งทอ (ผ้าที่ทอหรือถัก)

craftswoman - n. ช่างฝีมือหญิง (ผู้หญิงที่มีทักษะในงานฝีมือ)

distinguish - v. ทำให้แตกต่าง, แยกแยะ (ทำเครื่องหมายให้แยกออกจากกันหรือแตกต่าง)

embroider - v. ปัก (ตกแต่งด้วยงานปัก)

anaconda - n. งูอนาคอนดา (งูเหลือมขนาดใหญ่ชนิดหนึ่ง)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is stated about Sadith Silvano at the beginning of the article?

She is a musician who writes ancient songs.

She creates art inspired by ancient songs.

She is 36 years old and primarily focuses on modern art.

She is a Peruvian artist who only paints landscapes.

2. How does Sadith Silvano connect with her ancestors while painting?

By listening to traditional stories from elders.

By speaking directly to spirits in nature.

Through her singing voice as she paints.

By meditating in silence before starting her work.

3. According to Sadith Silvano, what helps artists connect to nature and their elders?

The specific colors and materials they use.

The inspiration derived from music.

The quiet environment of their workshop.

The physical presence of their elders.

4. Where did Sadith Silvano originally come from, before moving to Lima?

A large urban center in the Amazon.

Paoyhan, a Shipibo-Konibo Indigenous community.

The surroundings of the Uyacali river.

A different country in South America.

5. What does Silvano emphasize about her artwork in Paragraph 7?

Its commercial value and market demand.

Its modern aesthetic and unique style.

Its sacred nature and blessing with the energy of songs.

Its historical accuracy and cultural preservation.

6. What does official data reveal about the Shipibo-Konibo people in Peru?

Their population is declining rapidly due to illness.

Most of them still live in their ancestral Amazonian lands.

Many have moved to urban areas like Lima.

They are primarily found near the Andes mountains.

7. What significant recognition did 'kené' textiles receive in 2008?

They were featured in an international fashion magazine.

They were declared a national treasure by UNESCO.

They were declared part of the 'Cultural Heritage of the Nation' by the Peruvian government.

They became the official uniform for Peruvian artists.

8. According to Shipibo craftswomen, what unique aspect does each kené design convey?

The specific price and materials used for the textile.

The latest fashion trends in Peruvian cities.

A woman's community, her worldview, and beliefs.

The number of ancient songs known by the artist.

9. What is characteristic of Paoyhan, Silvano's hometown, according to the article?

It is easily accessible from Lima by a short boat trip.

Most locals primarily speak Spanish and other foreign languages.

It is a remote area where locals mainly speak Shipibo and houses lack locks.

It is a modern community with advanced security systems.

10. How did Adela Sampayo acquire her healing skills?

Through formal medical training in an urban clinic.

By studying ancient books on herbal remedies.

From her mother's traditional medicine practices in the Amazon.

By learning from other healers after moving to Cantagallo.

11. How does Adela Sampayo express her worldview through textiles?

By painting intricate designs on the fabric.

By weaving complex patterns that tell stories.

By embroidering tales and meanings with each thread.

By creating sculptures from textile waste.

12. What is the significance of the anaconda in Silvano's culture?

It is seen as a dangerous predator that must be avoided.

It is considered a protector and a god that provides for them.

It symbolizes wisdom and the changing seasons.

It is a common animal used for food and traditional rituals.

13. How did colonization impact the Shipibo-Konibo people's worldview regarding their traditional beliefs?

It completely eradicated all their ancient spiritual practices.

It reinforced their original belief systems, making them stronger.

It introduced Catholicism, leading to a changed but respectful coexistence of beliefs.

It caused widespread abandonment of all religious practices.

14. How do Shipibo women, including Sadith Silvano, typically cope with difficult times and suffering?

By seeking financial assistance from the government.

By retreating into complete isolation from their community.

By engaging in designing, painting, and singing as therapy.

By immediately moving back to their ancestral villages.

15. What final advice do mothers pass down to their daughters for healing from emotional pain?

To confront their problems directly and demand respect.

To seek help from the community elders and male leaders.

To use painting and singing with their kené as a form of self-healing and freedom.

To accept their fate and endure the difficulties in silence.